From Data to Decisions: Writing and Analyzing Evaluation Reports in Health Professions Education

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Objectives

By the end of this workshop, participants will be able to:

- Identify the key components of an effective evaluation report.
- Apply a framework for structuring an evaluation report.
- Analyze an evaluation report to draw meaningful conclusions and make recommendations.
- Critically appraise the clarity, coherence, and utility of evaluation findings.

Anatomy of a Good Evaluation Report

- Purpose of an evaluation report
- Core components:
- Summary
- Background & Purpose
- Evaluation Questions
- Methodology
- Findings
- Interpretation & Discussion
- Conclusions & Recommendations
- Limitations
- Appendices (e.g., tools, raw data)

Framework for Structuring an Evaluation Report

1. Introduction

- **Context:** Background of the program or intervention.
- **Purpose:** Why the evaluation was done.
- **Stakeholders:** Who is the report for?

2. Description of the Program

- **Goals and Objectives:** What the program intended to achieve.
- **Activities and Components:** What was implemented.
- **Target Population:** Who participated or benefited.

3. Evaluation Design

- **Evaluation Questions:** Clearly defined, focused questions.
- **Indicators and Criteria:** What success looks like.
- **Data Collection Methods:** Surveys, interviews, observations, etc.
- **Sampling:** Who and how many were involved.

4. Findings

- **Data Presentation:** Charts, graphs, themes from qualitative responses.

- **Analysis:** Interpretation of the data in relation to the questions.

- **Comparisons:** Benchmarks, pre-post comparisons, or subgroup analysis.

5. Discussion

- **Key Insights:** What the findings mean.
- **Unexpected Results:** Any surprises or contradictions.
- **Implications:** For practice, policy, curriculum, or further study.

6. Conclusions and Recommendations

- **Summary of Findings:** Linked back to the evaluation questions.
- **Recommendations:** Actionable, realistic, and evidence-based.
- **Next Steps:** Suggestions for future evaluation or improvement.

7. Appendices

- Instruments used (e.g., survey forms)
- Detailed data tables
- Workshop agendas or program logic models

Sample evaluation report

- Zehra T, Ali R, Sultan A, Hussain A. Needs assessment for faculty development in health professions education at a medical university in Karachi, Pakistan.
- Rehman R, Ali R, Moazzam H, Shaikh S. Utilization focused evaluation at Bahria University Medical & Dental College. Pakistan Journal of Medical Sciences. 2017 Jul;33(4):849.

Critical analysis of an evaluation

Systematically reviewing

- Quality,
- Credibility,
- Utility, and
- Relevance.

1. Clarity of Purpose and Context

- **Is the rationale clear?**

Does the report explain *why* the evaluation was conducted
(e.g., new curriculum, pilot workshop, assessment reform)?

- **Is the context adequately described?**

Setting, target audience (students, faculty), institutional background.

2. Evaluation Questions

Are they specific, measurable, and meaningful?

Good evaluation questions guide data collection and reporting.

- **Do they address both process and outcomes?**

E.g., "Was the simulation effective?" *and* "What were student perceptions?"

⚠️ **Red flag:** Vague or missing questions.

3. Methodology

- **Is the design appropriate?**

(qualitative, quantitative, or mixed-methods)

- **Is the sample described?**

Size, selection criteria, response rate.

- **Are the tools valid and reliable?**

E.g., was a validated survey used?
✅ **Look for:** Triangulation of data (e.g., surveys + interviews + observations).

4. Data Presentation and Interpretation

- **Is the data clearly presented?**
Charts, tables, themes from open responses.
- **Are findings linked to evaluation questions?**
- **Is interpretation balanced?**
Avoids overgeneralization or unsupported conclusions.

⚠️ **Red flag:** Only reporting positive results without acknowledging challenges.

5. Analysis and Discussion

- **Does the analysis go beyond description?**
  Look for critical thinking: *Why* did something work or not work?
- **Are alternative explanations considered?**
- **Does the report reflect on implications for practice or policy?**

6. Conclusions and Recommendations

- **Are conclusions logical and based on findings?**
- **Are recommendations practical and actionable?**
- **Is there a plan for follow-up or use of findings?**
- **Look for:** Realistic suggestions tied to specific findings.

7. Limitations

- **Are limitations acknowledged?**
  E.g., small sample, short duration, potential bias.
- **Do they discuss the impact of these limitations on validity?**

Thanks